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Teacher Handout Folder

Ten printable one-page handouts to accompany Using Spanish to Teach Spanish-Speaking English Learners in the Content Classroom by Richard A. Daniel

For: grades 9-12 math, science, social studies, and ELA teachers with Spanish-speaking English learners at ELPA21 Emerging and Progressing levels, including long-term ELs and newcomers. No Spanish fluency required. **Click a tab** to open a handout; every page has side tabs and a "Back to folder" link.

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QUICK REFERENCE

Top 10 Strategies for Using Spanish

1

Ten moves any content teacher can try next week, no Spanish fluency required

The big idea: A student's first language is not an obstacle to learning English; it is one of the best tools for learning English *and* content. This does not mean teaching in Spanish. It means inviting students to use Spanish strategically to think, plan, discuss, and check understanding, while you teach in English and hold high expectations for English output. You do not need to speak Spanish to do any of this.

1 Say it out loud

"Think and talk in any language; write in English." Post it and repeat it. Many students were told in past classrooms that Spanish was not allowed.

Piensen y hablen en cualquier idioma; escriban en inglés.

2 Teach cognate patterns

-tion / -ción, -ty / -dad, -ous / -oso, -ly / -mente, s + consonant / es + consonant. Treat patterns as clues, not rules.

nación, gravedad, famoso, rápidamente, estructura

3 Flag false cognates

Pre-teach the "false friends" in your subject. Students love catching them, and they become the experts.

argumento, carácter, realizar, actual, éxito, celda, billón

4 Build a bilingual word wall

10 to 20 key unit terms, English in one color and Spanish in another, a visual for each, a symbol for cognates. Point to it while you teach.

5 Use student-made glossaries

English term, Spanish, "my explanation (any language)," picture or example. For long-term ELs, push the English explanation over time.

6 Preview-View-Review

Spanish preview (short video, summary, or same-language brainstorm), English lesson, Spanish review, then English output (Freeman & Freeman, 2007).

7 Talk, Plan, Write

Partners talk in any language (2 to 3 min), plan in any language, then write and share in English. Hold students accountable for the English step.

8 Pair strategically

Plan pairs by English level, Spanish level, content knowledge, and personality. Give roles, rotate partners, and ask students privately what works.

9 Post bilingual sentence frames

3 to 4 frames per task, not 20. Full frames for Emerging, starters plus a word bank for Progressing, then fade. Underline the "glue" words.

10 Assess content fairly

Bilingual directions, a "plan in any language" box, separate content and language rubric rows. Use translation tools for words and short phrases only, never student data.

Planea aquí en cualquier idioma.

KNOW YOUR LEARNERS

- **Long-term ELs** often sound fluent socially; academic reading and writing still developing. Use Spanish mostly for **talk**; push English **writing**. Don't assume Spanish literacy.
- **Newcomers** need belonging, routines, a buddy, Spanish previews, and glossaries. Credit content shown in Spanish.
- **Ask, don't assume.** Some students speak an Indigenous language; not all Hispanic students are ELs.

THE TWO-QUESTION TEST

Not sure whether a use of Spanish is helping? Ask:

- **Is it helping the student understand the content?**
- **Is it moving the student toward stronger English?**

If both answers are no, adjust. If either is yes, it is probably a good use.

Research behind these moves: Cummins (2001), Moll et al. (1992), García et al. (2017), Lubliner & Hiebert (2011). Full references are in the ebook.

Math Cognates and False Cognates

2

High-frequency academic vocabulary for Algebra I, Geometry, and beyond

True cognates SAME MEANING

English	Español	English	Español
algebra	álgebra	perimeter	perímetro
angle	ángulo	perpendicular	perpendicular
area	área	polygon	polígono
coefficient	coeficiente	polynomial	polinomio
congruent	congruente	probability	probabilidad
constant	constante	proportion	proporción
coordinate	coordenada	quadratic	cuadrático
diameter	diámetro	radius	radio
equation	ecuación	rectangle	rectángulo
equivalent	equivalente	sequence	secuencia
exponent	exponente	simplify	simplificar
expression	expresión	symmetry	simetría
fraction	fracción	theorem	teorema
function	función	triangle	triángulo
hypotenuse	hipotenusa	variable	variable
linear	lineal	vertex	vértice
parallel	paralelo	volume	volumen

Accent marks and ¡ ¿ are highlighted in **orange**. Copy them carefully; students who learned to write in Spanish will notice.

Not cognates: pre-teach these

English	Spanish
slope	pendiente
average / mean	promedio / media
integer	número entero
inequality	desigualdad
square root	raíz cuadrada
greater than / less than	mayor que / menor que
ratio	razón
rate of change	tasa de cambio
graph (near-cognate)	gráfica

False cognates WATCH OUT

English	Look-alike	Spanish meaning
billion	billón	a million millions (English **trillion**). A billion is *mil millones*.
large	largo	**long**. Large is *grande*.
rate	rata	a **rat**. A rate is *tasa*.
realize	realizar	to **carry out**; *realiza la operación* = do the operation.
actual	actual	**current**. Actual is *real*.
mean (average)	significar	what a translation tool may give for "mean." Average is *media* or *promedio*.

MATH ALERT: NUMBERS ARE WRITTEN DIFFERENTLY

In many Spanish-speaking countries (for example, Spain, Colombia, and Argentina), a **comma** marks the decimal and a **period** separates thousands: *3,5* means 3.5 and *1.000* means one thousand. Mexico and much of Central America generally use the U.S. convention. If a student writes 3,5, it may not be an error. Ask, then teach the U.S. convention explicitly. Long division is also often laid out differently; invite students to show their method.

FRAME FOR SLOPE

The slope is ___, which means ___.

La pendiente es ___, lo que significa que ___.

Require **rate** and **per** (*por*) in explanations. Patterns to teach: -tion / -ción (equation), -ty / -dad (probability), ph, th / f, t (theorem / teorema).

Science Cognates

3

Biology, chemistry, physics, and earth science terms Spanish speakers may already know

True cognates SAME MEANING

English	Español	English	Español
acceleration	**aceleración**	gravity	**gravedad**
adaptation	**adaptación**	hypothesis	**hipótesis**
atom	**átomo**	mass	**masa**
bacteria	**bacterias**	mineral	**mineral**
chemical	**químico**	molecule	**molécula**
chromosome	**cromosoma**	nucleus	**núcleo**
classify	**clasificar**	observe	**observar**
conclusion	**conclusión**	organism	**organismo**
density	**densidad**	photosynthesis	**fotosíntesis**
ecosystem	**ecosistema**	protein	**proteína**
electricity	**electricidad**	reaction	**reacción**
element	**elemento**	species	**especie**
energy	**energía**	temperature	**temperatura**
evolution	**evolución**	theory	**teoría**
experiment	**experimento**	variable	**variable**
gene	**gen**	velocity	**velocidad**

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Not cognates: pre-teach these

English	Spanish
cell (biology)	**célula**
weight	**peso**
heat	**calor**
light	**luz**
mixture	**mezcla**
food chain	**cadena alimenticia**
trait	**rasgo**
force (near-cognate)	**fuerza**

UNIT CLUSTER: PHOTOSYNTHESIS

fotosíntesis · *cloroplasto* · *energía* · *glucosa* · *dióxido de carbono* · *oxígeno*

Frame: Because ___, the plant ___. As a result, ___.
Debido a que ___, la planta ___. Como resultado, ___.

False cognates WATCH OUT

English	Look-alike	Spanish meaning
cell	**celda**	a **jail cell** or spreadsheet cell. A living cell is *célula*.
exit (lab safety)	**éxito**	**success**. An exit is *salida*. Check your safety signs.
billion	**billón**	a million millions (English **trillion**). A billion is *mil millones*.
sensible	**sensible**	**sensitive** (*un instrumento sensible*). Sensible is *sensato*.
large	**largo**	**long**. Large is *grande*.
lecture	**lectura**	a **reading**. A lecture is *conferencia* or *clase*.

PATTERN CLUES FOR SCIENCE

ph, th / f, t: photosynthesis / *fotosíntesis*, theory / *teoría*
-ty / -dad: gravity / *gravedad*, density / *densidad*
-tion / -ción: reaction / *reacción*, evolution / *evolución*
Patterns are clues, not rules: scientist is *científico*, not "cientista."

IN THE LAB

Credit the concept in mixed-language answers. If a newcomer writes *"The plant uses luz to make glucosa,"* give credit for the science, then teach the English words. Bilingual labeled diagrams let students show understanding with less dependence on English.

Social Studies Cognates

4

U.S. history, world history, government, economics, and geography vocabulary

True cognates SAME MEANING

English	Español	English	Español
agriculture	**agricultura**	imperialism	**imperialismo**
capitalism	**capitalismo**	independence	**independencia**
civilization	**civilización**	industry	**industria**
colony	**colonia**	justice	**justicia**
conflict	**conflicto**	legislature	**legislatura**
constitution	**constitución**	liberty	**libertad**
culture	**cultura**	migration	**migración**
democracy	**democracia**	movement	**movimiento**
discrimination	**discriminación**	organize	**organizar**
document	**documento**	population	**población**
economy	**economía**	president	**presidente**
federal	**federal**	reconstruction	**reconstrucción**
geography	**geografía**	region	**región**
history	**historia**	republic	**república**
immigration	**inmigración**	testimony	**testimonio**

Accent marks and ¡ ¿ are highlighted in **orange**. Copy them carefully; students who learned to write in Spanish will notice.

Not cognates: pre-teach these

English	Spanish
civil rights	**derechos civiles**
right to vote	**derecho al voto**
citizen	**ciudadano / ciudadana**
amendment	**enmienda**
slavery	**esclavitud**
primary source	**fuente primaria**
government (near-cognate)	**gobierno**
treaty	**tratado**

False cognates WATCH OUT

English	Look-alike	Spanish meaning
compromise	**compromiso**	usually a **commitment** or obligation. A compromise is *acuerdo mutuo* or *término medio*.
college	**colegio**	usually a **school** (often K-12). College is *universidad*.
actual / actually	**actual / actualmente**	**current / currently**. Actually is *en realidad*.
assist	**asistir**	to **attend**. To assist is *ayudar*.
discussion	**discusión**	often an **argument or quarrel**.
billion	**billón**	a million millions (English **trillion**). A billion is *mil millones*.

LANGUAGE NOTE: "AMERICA"

In Spanish, *América* usually means the whole hemisphere (North, Central, and South America), and *americano* can mean anyone from the Americas. The United States is *Estados Unidos*; a U.S. citizen is *estadounidense*. This can be a great discussion starter, not an error to correct.

FRAME FOR PRIMARY SOURCES

This primary source shows that ___ because ___.
Esta fuente primaria muestra que ___ porque ___.

Evidence language for long-term ELs: *according to* (*según*), *she states that*, *this suggests*.

Sensitivity: Discussions of rights, voting, and migration can touch on immigration or citizenship. Keep the focus on the history, welcome connections students choose to share, and never ask about students' or families' immigration status.

ELA Cognates and False Cognates

5

Literary and writing terms, plus the false friends that trip up readers

True cognates SAME MEANING

English	Español	English	Español
alliteration	**aliteración**	inference	**inferencia**
analysis	**análisis**	introduction	**introducción**
antagonist	**antagonista**	irony	**ironía**
author	**autor**	metaphor	**metáfora**
autobiography	**autobiografía**	narrator	**narrador**
biography	**biografía**	novel	**novela**
climax	**clímax**	paragraph	**párrafo**
conclusion	**conclusión**	perspective	**perspectiva**
conflict	**conflicto**	persuasive	**persuasivo**
context	**contexto**	poem	**poema**
dialogue	**diálogo**	protagonist	**protagonista**
evidence	**evidencia**	simile	**símil**
fiction	**ficción**	symbol	**símbolo**
tragedy	**tragedia**	theme	**tema**

Accent marks and ¡ ¿ are highlighted in **orange**. Copy them carefully; students who learned to write in Spanish will notice.

False cognates WATCH OUT

English word	Spanish look-alike	What the Spanish word actually means
character (in a story)	**carácter**	personality or temperament. A story character is *personaje*.
argument	**argumento**	in literature, often the **plot** of a story; also a line of reasoning. A quarrel is *discusión* or *pelea*.
discussion	**discusión**	often an **argument or quarrel**, not just a conversation.
lecture	**lectura**	a **reading**. A lecture is *conferencia* or *clase*.
realize	**realizar**	to **carry out** or accomplish. To realize is *darse cuenta*.
library	**librería**	**bookstore**. A library is *biblioteca*.
embarrassed	**embarazada**	**pregnant**. Embarrassed is *avergonzado/a* or *apenado/a*.
actual / actually	**actual / actualmente**	**current / currently**. Actually is *en realidad*.

Transitions for argument writing

English	Spanish
however	**sin embargo**
for example	**por ejemplo**
therefore	**por lo tanto**
as a result	**como resultado**
according to	**según**
in conclusion	**en conclusión**

FALSE-COGNATE MOMENT

Show *argument / argumento* and *discussion / discusión*. Ask Spanish speakers to explain the difference. Students become the experts.

Argument frame: I believe ___ because ___. For example, ___. Some people argue ___; however, ___.
Creo que ___ porque ___. Por ejemplo, ___. Algunas personas dicen que ___; sin embargo, ___.

Teacher Spanish Phrase Bank

6

Classroom directions, check-ins, and encouragement, with how to say them

TÚ OR USTEDES?

Use **tú** forms with **one** student and **ustedes** forms with the **whole class** (used throughout Latin America). With parents and other adults, use the respectful **usted** (see Handout 9). Add *por favor* (pohr fah-BOHR) to any direction.

PRONUNCIATION IN ONE MINUTE

Vowels are short and steady: a (ah), e (eh), i (ee), o (oh), u (oo). **h** is silent. **j**, and **g** before e or i, sound like a strong English h. **ll** and **y** sound like English y. **ñ** = "ny" as in *canyon*. **b** and **v** sound alike. **CAPITALS** below show the stressed syllable.

Classroom directions

English	To one student (tú)	To the class (ustedes)
Sit down.	**Siéntate.** SYEHN-tah-teh	**Siéntense.** SYEHN-tehn-seh
Listen.	**Escucha.** ehs-KOO-chah	**Escuchen.** ehs-KOO-chehn
Look at the board.	**Mira el pizarrón.** MEE-rah ehl pee-sah-RROHN	**Miren el pizarrón.** MEE-rehn ehl pee-sah-RROHN
Take out your notebook.	**Saca tu cuaderno.** SAH-kah too kwah-DEHR-noh	**Saquen sus cuadernos.** SAH-kehn soos kwah-DEHR-nohs
Open your book to page ___.	**Abre tu libro en la página ___.** AH-breh too LEE-broh ehn lah PAH-hee-nah	**Abran sus libros en la página ___.** AH-brahn soos LEE-brohs ehn lah PAH-hee-nah
Read the directions.	**Lee las instrucciones.** LEH-eh lahs eens-trook-SYOH-nehs	**Lean las instrucciones.** LEH-ahn lahs eens-trook-SYOH-nehs
Write your name.	**Escribe tu nombre.** ehs-KREE-beh too NOHM-breh	**Escriban su nombre.** ehs-KREE-bahn soo NOHM-breh
Raise your hand.	**Levanta la mano.** leh-BAHN-tah lah MAH-noh	**Levanten la mano.** leh-BAHN-tehn lah MAH-noh
Work with a partner.	**Trabaja con un compañero.** trah-BAH-hah kohn oon kohm-pah-NYEH-roh	**Trabajen en parejas.** trah-BAH-hehn ehn pah-REH-hahs
You have five minutes.	**Tienes cinco minutos.** TYEH-nehs SEEN-koh mee-NOO-tohs	**Tienen cinco minutos.** TYEH-nehn SEEN-koh mee-NOO-tohs
Turn in your work.	**Entrega tu trabajo.** ehn-TREH-gah too trah-BAH-hoh	**Entreguen su trabajo.** ehn-TREH-gehn soo trah-BAH-hoh
Let's begin.	**Vamos a empezar.** BAH-mohs ah ehm-peh-SAHR (same for one student or the class)	

Encouragement

English	Spanish + how to say it
Very good! / Excellent!	**¡Muy bien! / ¡Excelente!** mooy BYEHN / ehk-seh-LEHN-teh
Great work!	**¡Buen trabajo!** bwehn trah-BAH-hoh
Great idea!	**¡Qué buena idea!** keh BWEH-nah ee-DEH-ah
Keep it up!	**¡Sigue así!** SEE-geh ah-SEE
You can do it!	**¡Tú puedes!** too PWEH-dehs
Almost! Try again.	**¡Casi! Inténtalo otra vez.** KAH-see een-TEHN-tah-loh OH-trah behs
Mistakes help us learn.	**Los errores nos ayudan a aprender.** lohs eh-RROH-rehs nohs ah-YOO-dahn ah ah-prehn-DEHR
Your Spanish is a strength.	**Tu español es una fortaleza.** too ehs-pah-NYOHL ehs OO-nah fohr-tah-LEH-sah

Check-ins and language support

English	Spanish + how to say it
Welcome!	**¡Bienvenido! / ¡Bienvenida!** byehn-beh-NEE-doh (boy) / byehn-beh-NEE-dah (girl)
Do you need help?	**¿Necesitas ayuda?** neh-seh-SEE-tahs ah-YOO-dah
How do you pronounce your name?	**¿Cómo se pronuncia tu nombre?** KOH-moh seh proh-NOON-syah too NOHM-breh
You can say it in Spanish first.	**Puedes decirlo primero en español.** PWEH-dehs deh-SEER-loh pree-MEH-roh ehn ehs-pah-NYOHL
Now say it in English, please.	**Ahora dilo en inglés, por favor.** ah-OH-rah DEE-loh ehn een-GLEHS, pohr fah-BOHR

Start small: pick **three** phrases this week (a greeting, a direction, an encouragement) and use them daily. Let students correct your pronunciation; it makes them the experts.

Pizarrón is common in Mexico and Central America; *pizarra* is also widely understood. *Compañero* = a male partner or a partner in general; *compañera* = a female partner. Respellings use Latin American pronunciation (z and c before e or i sound like s).

Sentence Frames by ELPA21 Level

7

Emerging vs. Progressing frames for discussion and writing, English with Spanish support

EMERGING
Understands simple, familiar English, especially with visuals; speaks in words or short phrases. **Give the full frame**, a word bank, visuals, and a Spanish-speaking partner for every response.

PROGRESSING
Follows much of class talk; writing shows ideas but limited academic vocabulary and sentence variety. **Give a sentence starter and a word bank**, then fade the support over the year.

Discussing — TALK IN ANY LANGUAGE

Purpose	EMERGING: full frame	PROGRESSING: academic frame
Share an idea	I think ___. *Creo que ___.*	I think ___ because ___. *Creo que ___ porque ___.*
Agree	I agree. *Estoy de acuerdo.*	I agree with ___ because ___. *Estoy de acuerdo con ___ porque ___.*
Disagree	I disagree. *No estoy de acuerdo.*	I respectfully disagree with ___ because ___. *Con respeto, no estoy de acuerdo con ___ porque ___.*
Build on an idea	I want to add ___. *Quiero agregar ___.*	In addition to what ___ said, I think ___. *Además de lo que dijo ___, pienso que ___.*
Ask for help	Can you repeat that, please? *¿Puedes repetirlo, por favor?*	Can you explain what you mean by ___? *¿Puedes explicar qué quieres decir con ___?*
Clarify a word	What does ___ mean? *¿Qué significa ___?*	I don't understand ___. Is it similar to ___? *No entiendo ___. ¿Es similar a ___?*

Writing — WRITE IN ENGLISH

Purpose	EMERGING: full frame	PROGRESSING: academic frame
Use evidence	The text says ___. *El texto dice ___.*	According to the text, ___. This shows that ___. *Según el texto, ___. Esto muestra que ___.*
Cause and effect	___ because ___. *___ porque ___.*	Because ___, ___. As a result, ___. *Debido a que ___, ___. Como resultado, ___.*
Compare	___ is like ___. *___ es como ___.*	___ is similar to ___ because ___. However, ___. *___ es similar a ___ porque ___. Sin embargo, ___.*
Sequence	First, ___. Then, ___. *Primero, ___. Luego, ___.*	First, ___. Next, ___. Finally, ___. *Primero, ___. Después, ___. Finalmente, ___.*
Describe data	The graph shows ___. *La gráfica muestra ___.*	The data show that ___, which means ___. *Los datos muestran que ___, lo que significa que ___.*
Conclude	I learned ___. *Aprendí ___.*	In conclusion, ___. *En conclusión, ___.*

One frame per subject

MATH
The slope is ___, which means ___.
La pendiente es ___, lo que significa que ___.

SCIENCE
My hypothesis is that if ___, then ___.
Mi hipótesis es que si ___, entonces ___.

SOCIAL STUDIES
This primary source shows that ___ because ___.
Esta fuente primaria muestra que ___ porque ___.

ELA
The author uses ___ to show ___.
El autor usa ___ para mostrar ___.

Make frames work harder: post 3 to 4 frames per task, not 20. Underline the academic "glue" words and teach them explicitly: *because* (porque), *according to* (según), *however* (sin embargo), *as a result* (como resultado), *for example* (por ejemplo). Check each student's ELPA21 domain scores with the ENL teacher; many are stronger in speaking than writing.

NEWCOMER SUPPORT

Newcomer First-Week Checklist

8

A day-by-day plan for welcoming a newly arrived Spanish-speaking student

Newcomers vary widely. Some had strong prior schooling and may know your content well; some had limited or interrupted schooling (SLIFE); some speak an Indigenous language (for example, K'iche', Mam, or Q'anjob'al) and Spanish is their second language. Many are also adjusting to a new country, new routines, and family changes. **Predictable routines, a welcoming partner, and a teacher who says their name correctly matter enormously.**

Before the student arrives (or on day 1)

- ☐ Ask the ENL teacher for ELPA21 scores, prior schooling, home language(s), and the EL plan.
- ☐ Learn how to pronounce the student's name. Practice it.
- ☐ Choose a buddy: a kind, bilingual classmate. Plan to rotate the role.
- ☐ Pick a seat near the front, close to the buddy and the word wall.
- ☐ Print a bilingual glossary for the current unit.
- ☐ Prepare a checked Spanish version of key class documents (syllabus, routines, lab safety). Keep the English beside it.
- ☐ Find out the family's preferred language for calls and messages.

Day 1: welcome

- ☐ Greet the student by name at the door.
- ☐ Introduce the buddy and show where things are.
- ☐ Walk through the daily routine with visuals (agenda, warm-up, exit ticket).
- ☐ Give the five-question language survey in English and Spanish.
- ☐ Say, "You can use Spanish to think and talk here."

Days 2 to 3: access

- ☐ Give a short Spanish preview before each lesson (video, summary, or partner talk).
- ☐ Use visuals, gestures, demonstrations, and the word wall.
- ☐ Post bilingual directions for every task.
- ☐ Provide full sentence frames and a word bank.
- ☐ Check in by name at least once each class.

Days 4 to 5: evidence of learning

- ☐ Grade content separately from English.
- ☐ Accept Spanish or mixed-language answers on content checks when you can understand them.
- ☐ Track small English wins: a labeled diagram, three key terms, one framed sentence.
- ☐ Send a short positive message home in Spanish and English.
- ☐ Meet the ENL teacher: what is working, what to adjust.

SAY THIS IN WEEK ONE

¡Bienvenido! / ¡Bienvenida! Welcome! (boy / girl)

Me alegra que estés aquí. I'm glad you're here.

¿Cómo se pronuncia tu nombre? How do you pronounce your name?

Soy tu maestro / maestra de ___. I'm your ___ teacher. (male / female teacher)

Él / Ella te puede ayudar. He / She can help you.

¿Necesitas ayuda? Do you need help?

AVOID

- Seating newcomers silently in the back or leaving them isolated.
- Giving only translated worksheets with no English exposure.
- Making one bilingual student the full-time translator.
- Assuming Spanish literacy, or assuming Spanish is the home language.
- Asking about immigration status, or questions that could be heard that way.

Five-question language survey GIVE IN BOTH LANGUAGES

English	Spanish
What language(s) do you speak at home?	**¿Qué idioma(s) hablas en casa?**
Can you read and write in Spanish? A little, some, or a lot?	**¿Puedes leer y escribir en español? ¿Un poco, algo o mucho?**
Where did you go to school before?	**¿Dónde estudiaste antes?**
What helps you learn best in class?	**¿Qué te ayuda a aprender mejor en clase?**
What do you want me to know about you?	**¿Qué quieres que yo sepa de ti?**

Calling Families in Spanish

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Formal usted phrases and a short call script for sharing good news

WHY USTED?

With parents and other adults, use the respectful **usted** form: *¿Tiene...?* (not *¿Tienes...?*) and *su* for "your." It shows respect, and families notice the effort.

BEFORE YOU DIAL

Check the family's **preferred language**. A parent's last name may differ from the student's (many families use two surnames), so ask "Are you ___'s mother?" instead of assuming "Mrs. [student's last name]." Practice the script aloud once.

A short positive call script GOOD NEWS CALL

Step	Say (usted)	Meaning
1 Greet	**Buenas tardes. ¿Es usted la mamá / el papá de ___?**	Good afternoon. Are you ___'s mother / father?
2 Introduce yourself	**Soy ___, maestro / maestra de ___ de su hijo / hija.**	I'm ___, your son's / daughter's ___ teacher.
3 Say why you called	**Llamo para darle una buena noticia.**	I'm calling to give you some good news.
4 Share the news	**A su hijo / hija le va bien en la clase. Hoy ___ explicó muy bien su respuesta.**	Your son / daughter is doing well in class. Today ___ explained their answer very well.
5 Invite questions	**¿Tiene alguna pregunta?**	Do you have any questions?
6 Ask how to stay in touch	**¿Cuál es la mejor manera de comunicarme con usted? ¿Prefiere llamadas, mensajes de texto o correo electrónico?**	What is the best way to contact you? Do you prefer calls, text messages, or email?
7 Close warmly	**Gracias por su apoyo. Que tenga un buen día.**	Thank you for your support. Have a good day.

If you get stuck

English	Spanish
Excuse me, my Spanish is limited.	**Disculpe, mi español es limitado.**
Can you speak more slowly, please?	**¿Puede hablar más despacio, por favor?**
Can you repeat that, please?	**¿Puede repetirlo, por favor?**
I'm going to call again with an interpreter.	**Voy a llamar otra vez con un intérprete.**
One moment, please. I'll get an interpreter.	**Un momento, por favor. Voy a buscar un intérprete.**

More family phrases

English	Spanish
Nice to meet you.	**Mucho gusto.**
Thank you for coming.	**Gracias por venir.**
Your son / daughter works very hard.	**Su hijo / hija trabaja mucho.**
Thank you for your support.	**Gracias por su apoyo.**

VOICEMAIL

Buenas tardes, habla ___, maestro / maestra de ___ de ___. Llamo para darle una buena noticia. Mi número es ___. Gracias.

Good afternoon, this is ___, ___'s ___ teacher. I'm calling with good news. My number is ___. Thank you.

USE A QUALIFIED INTERPRETER FOR ANYTHING SERIOUS

Your few phrases are for warm, routine contact. For **grades or failing concerns, behavior, attendance, IEP or 504 meetings, health, and conferences**, request a qualified interpreter through the front office or ENL program and plan ahead. Federal guidance (U.S. Departments of Justice and Education, 2015) cautions against relying on students, siblings, or untrained staff to interpret. **Never ask about immigration status** (see *Plyler v. Doe*, 1982). Keep student data out of free translation tools.

COMMON PITFALLS

Do's and Don'ts of Using the Home Language

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Avoid the most common pitfalls and what to do instead

Even teachers with the best intentions can fall into habits that undercut students' learning or dignity. Here are the most common pitfalls, with better alternatives.

DO	DON'T
✓ Rotate partners and use bilingual materials, visuals, and tools for routine needs. Thank helpers and ask privately whether they are comfortable.	✗ Make the same bilingual student the class translator.
✓ Keep English and Spanish side by side. Translate directions and key ideas, not entire texts.	✗ Translate everything or hand out Spanish-only materials.
✓ Ask students about their languages and check EL status with the ENL teacher.	✗ Assume every Hispanic student speaks Spanish or is an English learner.
✓ Use oral Spanish with long-term ELs unless they tell you otherwise.	✗ Assume Spanish speakers can read academic Spanish.
✓ Set expectations: "Talk in any language, write in English." Redirect off-task talk as you would in English.	✗ Make "English only" rules or punish students for using Spanish.
✓ Make most of the Spanish students hear from you welcoming, instructional, and encouraging.	✗ Use Spanish only for discipline.
✓ Keep grade-level content and add scaffolds: frames, glossaries, visuals, previews, and structured talk.	✗ Lower expectations by giving easier content instead of support.
✓ Use Spanish for thinking and English for the final product. Fade supports over time.	✗ Let Spanish replace English output for long-term ELs.
✓ Ask how to pronounce each name, practice, and get it right. Names carry identity.	✗ Mispronounce or anglicize names.
✓ Treat regional differences in words as an interesting discussion.	✗ Treat "Spanish" as one thing or correct regional words as errors.
✓ Give newcomers a buddy, a front seat, a glossary, visuals, and a daily check-in by name.	✗ Leave newcomers silent in the back.
✓ Request a qualified interpreter for family conferences.	✗ Ask students to interpret at family conferences.

TRANSLATION TOOLS: HELPFUL SERVANTS, UNRELIABLE MASTERS

- **Do** use them for single words, short phrases, the gist of directions, and live check-ins.
- **Do** write clear, idiom-free English first, and have key materials checked.
- **Don't** paste student names, grades, or IEP or 504 details into free public tools.
- **Don't** trust them with technical terms (*cell*, *mean*) or idioms.

THE TWO-QUESTION TEST

- **Is it helping the student understand the content?**
- **Is it moving the student toward stronger English?**

If both answers are no, adjust. If either is yes, it is probably a good use of Spanish.